

Transforming Certification for Better Care

ABMS CONFERENCE 2026

From Initiatives to Infrastructure: Maturing and Embedding Inclusive Practices for Lasting Organizational Impact

**Wednesday, September 16, 2026 | 3:00 – 4:00pm
CT**

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Health Equity Work at ABIM

Lorna Lynn, MD

SVP, Health Equity and
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Disclosures

- I am a full-time employee of ABIM
- I am a member of the ABMS Committee on Culture, Engagement and Impact

ABIM's Equity Work

- Health Equity Content
- Fairness Reviews
- Research
- Annual Reports
- Needs-Based Initial Certification Fee Assistance Program

ABIM's Commitment to Health Equity

June 2025 Health Equity Statement:

As the current leaders of ABIM and the ABIM Foundation, we affirm our ongoing commitment to advancing health equity in furtherance of the missions and work of both organizations.

- **Health equity content** in our assessments, based on science and evidence related to health disparities
- **Structured reviews of exam questions**, to identify and address potentially biased questions (**Fairness Reviews**)
- **Research** to contribute to improved assessment strategies

*Board level oversight via **Equity Committee***

Health Equity Content

- ABIM-certified internists and specialists should be familiar with the **decades of high-quality research** on health equity and social drivers of health
- Including health equity items on our assessments **sends a signal** to training programs and CME providers
- Health equity content is **grounded in clinically relevant topics** in each discipline (cross-content)

Terms and definitions

- **Health equity** is a human right that allows **everyone** to achieve the **best attainable health and outcomes**, by overcoming all avoidable barriers

Adapted from the American College of Cardiology

- An item is considered a **health equity item** if the ability to answer the question correctly demonstrates **knowledge and skills that could reduce avoidable disparities in health or health care**. This includes reducing disparities based on **gender, race/ethnicity, age, geography, social drivers of health and intersectionality**.

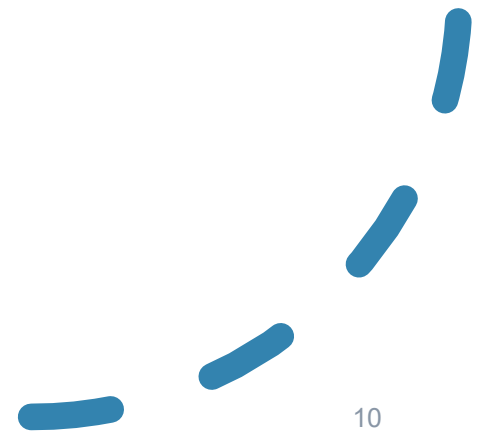
Types of Health Equity Questions

- **Barriers to care**, including transportation challenges, lack of insurance, low health literacy, provider bias, language barriers
- **Differences in health outcomes**, including higher incidence or mortality rates for specific populations, delayed diagnoses
- Understanding needs for **differentiation in care**, including situations when housing, income, or insurance make first line treatment unattainable
- Evidence-based **physician interventions** to address health disparities, including preventive care and screening, patient education, telehealth, cultural competency

Health Equity Content Development

- **Training** for staff, item writers, approval committee members
 - **Common understanding** of goals, definitions/terms
 - Identification of best **blueprint areas**
- Physician **consultants**
- **Iterative** work
- Items held to **same standards** as all ABIM items
 - Pre-test performance
 - References and rationales

Examples



Purpose of Fairness Reviews

- To ensure a **fair assessment** for every physician to demonstrate their clinical knowledge and skills regardless of physicians' group memberships such as **medical school type, gender or race/ethnicity**.
- Physician performance on an assessment should be **based solely on their clinical ability** and not extraneous factors associated with group membership.

Fairness Review Concepts

Statistical Review

- Differential Item Functioning (DIF)
- Identify potentially biased items by using a statistical tool

Sensitivity Review

- Items reviewed by a diverse panel of content experts
- Identify truly biased items

Pilot results and key takeaways

- **Fewer than 2% of items** in each pilot discipline were determined to have bias
- **Fewer items are flagged for bias with every passing year** (“cleaning up the pools we already have”)
- **Very strong buy-in** from Subject Matter Experts (SME’s) and staff
- Most common sources of item bias:
 - **Regional differences** in exposure
 - **Cultural differences** in item interpretation
- **Small numbers are a big challenge**

Research

- Boards are **uniquely positioned** to answer some research questions
- **Collaboration** strengthens research
- ***Non-US Born Physicians in the US Internal Medicine Workforce*** (Giacomo Meille et al, JAMA, August 12, 2026)
- ***Adoption of Internal Medicine Milestones Ratings and Changes in Bias Against Black, Latino, and Asian Internal Medicine Residents*** (Bradley Gray et al, Annals of Internal Medicine, December 26, 2023)

Annual Reports— new this year

Includes:

- Medical school type
- Sex
- Race/ethnicity, with trends over time
- Age



Needs-Based Certification Exam Fee Assistance Program

- **Originated in listening session** with Hispanic/Latino/Latina diplomates
- **Open to all** candidates (USMGs, IMGs) for **initial certification in internal medicine**
- **Needs-based**
 - **Program support** beyond salary
 - **Other financial obligations/resources**
- **Status:** ~850 received 50% exam fee credit this year (first year of program)

Thank you

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American Board of Family Medicine

Inclusion and Health Equity Activities at AFBM

Gary L. LeRoy, MD
Senior Vice President of Diplomate Experience



Disclosures

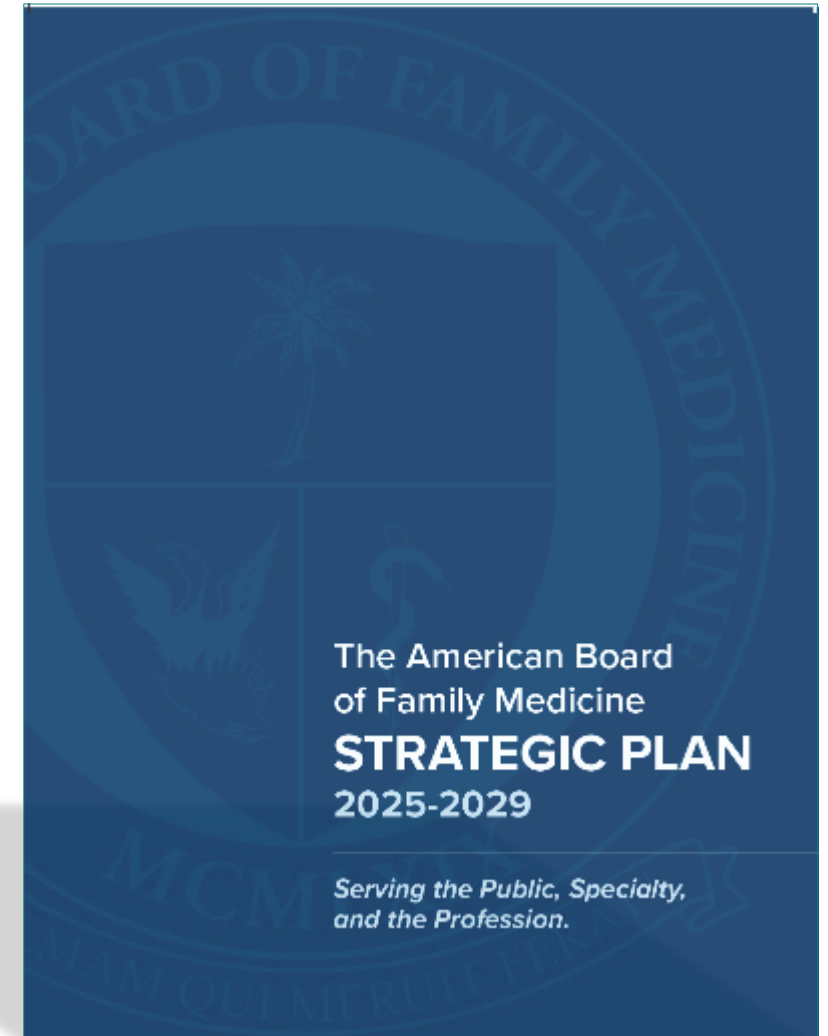
No disclosures to report.



Leadership and Governance

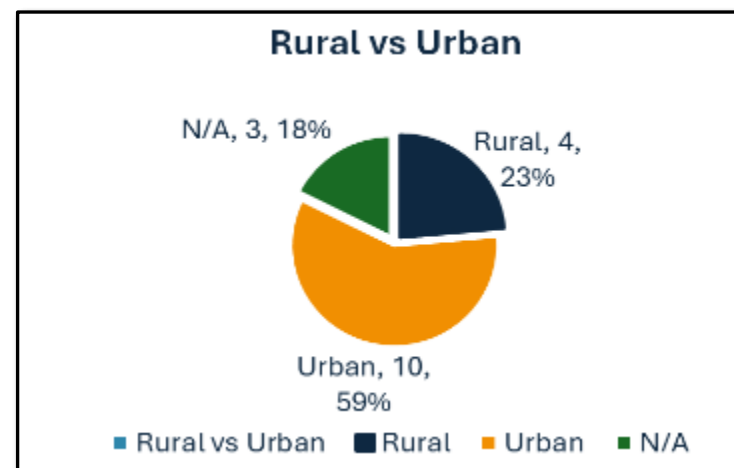
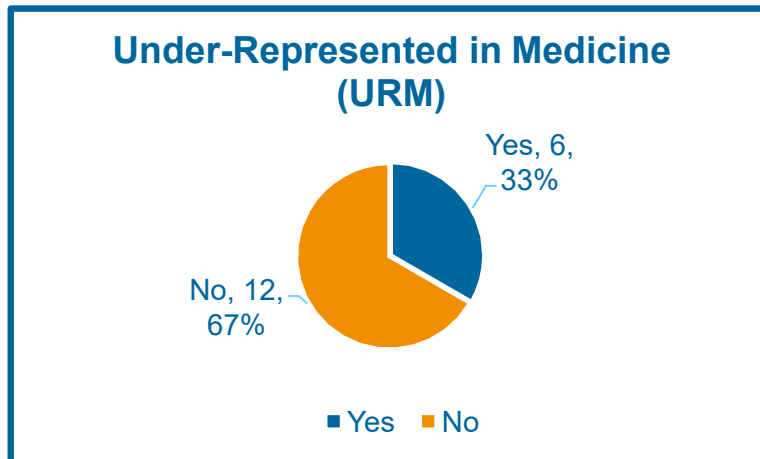
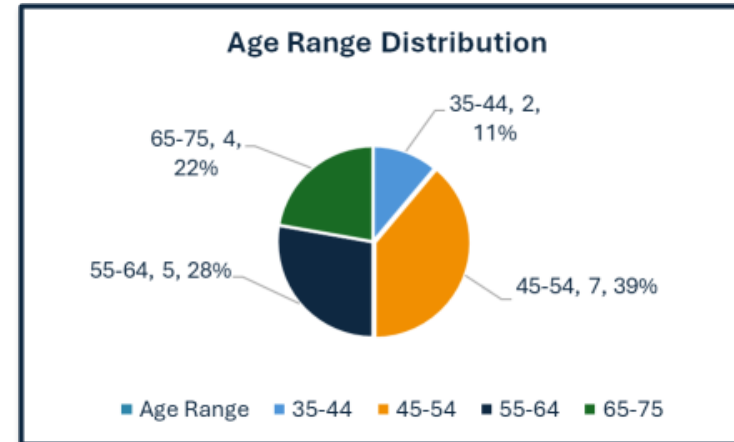
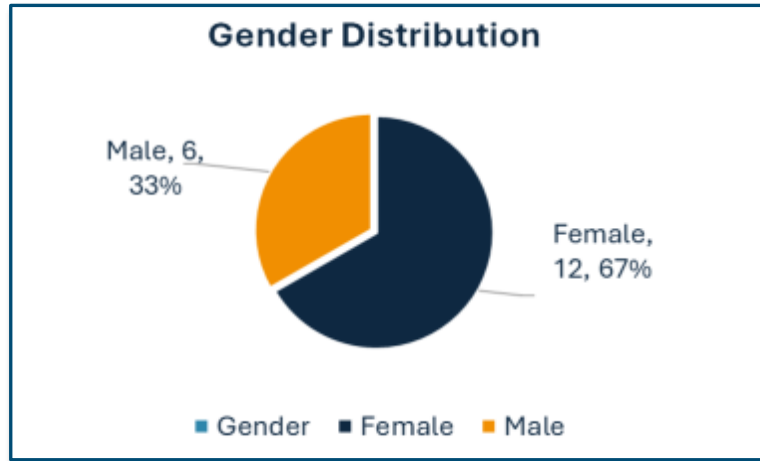
Goal #7 - Promote health equity in the practices of family physicians and the communities they serve.

The strategic need is to reaffirm ABFM's commitment to health equity as one of its core strategic initiatives, even as it recognizes with humility that mitigating health disparities is a challenging and long-term effort, needing both numerous partners and persistence.



Leadership and Governance

2026-2027 ABFM Board of Directors Representation



Leadership and Governance

Commitment to training the next generation of diverse researchers and future leaders.

- Pisacano Leadership Foundation Scholar
- James C. Puffer Fellowship (NAM)
- Visiting Scholars for Research and Health Policy



Staff Culture & Development

- Annual Juneteenth celebration and learning event
- Started in June 2023
- Paired with an educational article published internally and externally
- Local speaker lectures at our Lexington, Kentucky office on a cultural history or health equity theme tied to the article
- Followed by a Juneteenth luncheon and raffle of gift certificates to minority-owned restaurants
- **New this year** – Use Juneteenth as an optional Floating Holiday

JUNETEENTH



Staff Culture & Development



Assessments

- Since 2013, ABFM has captured race and ethnicity data to detect implicit bias in the certification exam.
- ABFM conducts an annual Differential Item Functioning (DIF) Analysis using a panel of physician volunteers to identify racial, ethnic, or gender bias.
- At this year's meeting in July, for the first time, the panel used a pre-trained AI tool (Copilot) to review flagged items.
- A blind comparison against panelist judgments tested how accurately the AI identified item bias.

2026 DIF Panel



Data

Publish Annual Health Equity Report for Board of Directors

- Includes equity updates and reports across each department in the organization.
- Examples include ***Health Equity In Action*** stories published externally on public website that highlight real-world examples of how Diplomates are working to reduce barriers to care.
- ABFM Research conducts regular surveys of family physicians across multiple points during their training and practice careers, not only during and shortly after residency training completion, but also when they complete phases of their continuous certification cycles.

Data

Periodic Health Equity Progress Report for public dissemination.

- ABFM Staff, board of directors, and volunteer representation
- Participation stats for health-equity-focused certification activities (self-assessment, performance improvement, etc.)
- Research studies and health policy updates focused on health equity topics.
- Health Equity In Action Diplomate Stories



Equity and Inclusion Initiatives Across Member Boards

Focus Area	American Board of Family Medicine	American Board of Internal Medicine	American Board of Surgery
Staff Culture & Development	• Juneteenth Celebration - June 19 - An annual staff learning event for ABFM staff. A topical speaker is invited to provided ABFM office in Lexington, KY a lecture discussing a cultural history and/or health equity topic. This is followed by a Juneteenth luncheon and raffle of gift certificates to selected minority owned restaurants.	• Martin Luther King Jr Day, Juneteenth, and Pride Month all highlighted • All staff given one paid day off for volunteer work (ABIM sponsored or personal choice) • Staff training (e.g., psychological safety, conflict resolution, implicit bias)	• Ada to fill in
Assessments	• Differential Item Functioning Panel - For the first time at their annual meeting the panel deployed a pre-trained AI (Copilot) application tasked to review flagged items. A blind comparison with panelist judges was used to evaluated the AI tool for its ability to correctly identify item bias.	• Health equity exam content • Fairness reviews (statistical review plus diverse subject matter expert panels)	
Leadership & Governance	• ABFM 2025-29 Strategic Plan - Strategic Goal 7 – Promote Health Equity – Reaffirm ABFM’s commitment to health equity as one of its core strategic initiatives, even as it recognizes with humility that mitigating health disparities is a challenging and long-term effort, needing both numerous partners and persistence.	• Intentional governance selection to include broad range of experience and perspective • BOD-level Equity Committee	
Data	• Health Equity Report – Report to the ABFM Board of Directors, Diplomates, and to the public about the progress of ABFM’s work in health equity. This is done by publishing an annual equity report to the BOD and including equity updates and reports in the ABFM President’s Message, Diplomat spotlight articles, blogs,	• Diplomate Annual Reports • Data obtained annually from AAMC • Self-report of gender, race, ethnicity, and heritage on physician portal	



THE AMERICAN
BOARD OF SURGERY

The ABS Journey: Building, Protecting and Refining Our Approach to DEI Work

Ada Okafor – General Counsel, Chief DEI Officer
AMERICAN BOARD OF SURGERY

Disclosures & Disclaimers

- General Counsel and Chief DEI Officer at ABS
- Member of ABMS' Committee on Culture Engagement and Impact (CCEI)
- No financial compensation for this presentation
- Wearing my DEI hat and presenting from a DEI lens, not legal lens
- This presentation does not contain any legal advice; it's general business information
- The information in the presentation is current as of September 2026

Overview

Building

Origin of ABS DEI Program

Protecting

Leadership Tier
Assessment Tier
Education Tier
Organizational Tier
Staff Tier

Refining

Our approach to DEI in 2026 and beyond

Building -- Origins of ABS DEI Program



2018 -- First implicit bias training for Council Members, Board of Directors, CE Examiners, and Staff



2019 -- Journal article explored gender bias on ABS General Surgery Certifying Exam, no evidence of bias found



Spring 2020 -- First large-scale demographic survey of diplomates and surgeon governance leaders



Fall 2020 -- Retreat on Institutional Racism in Surgery; DEI Ad Hoc Task Force formed with key recommendations



2021 -- DEI core priority in Strategic 5-Year Plan; Mission Statement Updated; Inaugural Chief DEI Officer appointed

Protecting – Our Five Tier DEI Program

Leadership Tier	Every Council Committee tasked with addressing DEI within their wheelhouse Dedicated DEI Committee provides expertise and support to other Council Committees and BOD
Assessment Tier	DIF analysis and bias review Fair and equitable exam training Inclusive language writing training ADA accessibility and accommodations taskforce
Education Tier	SCORE learning modules on DEI, disparities of care, and SDOH EPAs (launched 2023) enabling competency-based assessment
Organizational Tier	Partnerships with Member Boards for Diverse Voices Speaker Series Partnerships with ABMS (CCEI, EquiNet, DEI Taskforce); American College of Surgeons; Surgical Societies
Staff Tier	Ongoing DEI training, microlearning, resource clubs, newsletters, check-ins, and in-person events

Refining in the Current Landscape

- **DEI is at a critical moment**
- Lean into DEI, not lean out
- We have **unprecedented opportunities to do DEI differently**
- What worked in previously, may not work this year or years ahead...**and that's OK**
- We need to be **nimble, agile and responsive** to the anti-DEI movement, because movement won't stop until "DEI is dead," in their words
- But **the truth is** if DEI dies if we all give up and say ok no more DEI no more social justice no more equity no more fairness no more empathy, no more understanding -- the human and financial costs will be astronomical

The Path Forward – Assessing Risks

Legal

- EO targeting Board
- Civil compliance investigation from a Federal Agency
- Whistleblower lawsuit
- Negative social media campaign by activists

Financial

- Diplomates refuse to seek re/certification
- Staff resign loss of DEI expertise and institutional knowledge
- Costs to rehire new staff
- Costs to hire lawyers and external experts, modify internal and external documents, provide training for staff and governance leaders

Tax-Exempt Status

- Loss of tax-exempt status
- Not on or off switch
- Lengthy multi-step process with IRS
- Calculate cost of losing tax-exempt status, can your board still operate if you have \$\$\$ tax liability on net income?

Reputational

- Seen as performative
- Loss of trust and confidence
- “Trust is hard-earned, easily lost, and difficult to reestablish” ~ Former President of USC Carol Folt

The Path Forward – Derisking & Preparedness Strategies

Strategic Crisis Communication Consultant

- Crisis management and reputation protection plan
- Ensure strategic responses to Eos, federal investigations, whistleblower lawsuits, social media campaigns

Comprehensive Legal Audit

- Extensive DEI audit with interviews of key staff and governance leaders
- Report with audit results and recommendations

Post-Audit Periodic Review

- Annual reviews with triggers for interim review upon material legal or regulatory changes
- Periodically test policies against hypothetical challenges (reverse discrimination claims adverse impact findings)

Digital Footprint Audit

- Review and update website and social media accounts
- Establish policy for posting DEI/HE/SDOH-related content

The Path Forward – Reframing & Realigning Strategies

- **Reframe Nomenclature**
 - Inclusive Writing Retreat instead of DEI Writing Retreat
 - Fair and Equitable Exam Training instead of Implicit Bias Training
- **Focus on Skill-Based Hiring and Advancement**
 - Establish neutral, standardized criteria
 - Base decisions on qualifications, skills and performance
 - Avoid quotas, set-asides, and preferences
 - Create broader talent pipelines and transparent advancement pathways
- **Communicate in Terms of Business Outcomes**
 - Frame objectives around merit, skills, and fairness – not demographic targets
- **Tie DEI to Business Objectives**
 - DEI remains a business imperative; align with organizational values and mission
 - Measure DEI goals with core business objectives and KPIS

The Path Forward –Coalition Building

Internal; Within your Organization

- Can't afford to work in silos in this environment
- Build coalitions and support systems within your organization
- Establish free flow of information in your DEI ecosystem
- Build rapport with: Legal Counsel, Communications, IT, HR, Psychometricians, Exam Development, Exam Operations, Governance Leaders, Staff

External; Outside of your Organization

- ABMS Member Boards Community
- DEI Professionals (EquiNet, Diverse Voices Speaker Series, Training Examiners and Item Writers, Member Board DEI Taskforces)
- National, Regional, and Local Organizations focused on Nonprofits and/or DEI Professionals

Final Takeaways

Important to
stay calm in the chaos

Understand difference
between laws, regulations,
policy directives, city
ordinances and what **actually**
applies to your organization

Compliance **does not** mean
elimination

Work in tandem with Legal
Counsel to **identify risks**
then derisk

Coalition build within your
organization and with other
organizations

Refocus energy on
developing new playbook, a
new approach, new ways of
engaging, new ways of
thinking, and new language to
address this new phase in DEI



THE AMERICAN
BOARD OF SURGERY

Thank You!

Feedback and questions may be directed to dei@absurgery.org

Transforming Certification for Better Care

ABMS CONFERENCE 2026

Q&A



From Initiative to Infrastructure

Discuss at your table, then be ready to share one takeaway.

1

TABLE DISCUSSION

8 MINUTES

What inclusion-related effort in your organization is still ad hoc, but would benefit from being institutionalized?

What will you take back to your organization, and how can the member board community support you?

2

GROUP DEBRIEF

5 MINUTES

Share one thing you learned or one idea that stood out.



Connect with us

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